

Choosing Images for a Mood Board

A working note for selecting mood board images with intent, not just instinct

A mood board isn't a collection of images you like — it's a decision-making tool. Every image should answer a specific question about how the site should feel. This note walks through how to choose deliberately, not just aesthetically.

1. Start from what the board needs to prove

Before searching for a single image, write 3–5 adjectives that describe the target feeling — pulled from the brand messaging or story script, not invented on the spot. Every image should clearly support at least one of these words. If you can't say which adjective an image proves, it doesn't belong on the board.

2. Pull from multiple image categories

A board built only from UI screenshots becomes a copy reference, not a mood reference. Mix categories so the board captures a feeling, not just a layout:

Category	What it contributes
Color / texture	Abstract combinations and patterns that capture the palette's feeling, not just the palette itself
Photography	Real people and settings that ground the abstract feeling in the actual audience
UI / product references	Specific qualities worth borrowing — not limited to direct competitors
Illustration / iconography style	Flat vs. 3D, outlined vs. filled, geometric vs. organic — shapes character and icon decisions
Typography in context	How headline and body type feel together outside any one product

3. Filter every image through three questions

- **Does it match the palette direction**, or fight it? A serene pastel photo won't sit well next to a bold, saturated color system.
- **Does it respect the real constraints** — mobile-first layouts, low-bandwidth performance, bilingual or multi-script text? Desktop-only, single-language imagery won't translate to the actual product.
- **Does it feel authentic to the real audience**, or does it default to generic stock-app imagery? This is the easiest place for a board to quietly drift away from who the product is actually for.

4. Where to source images

Source	Best for
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Pinterest	Broad, fast exploration — search adjectives + “app design” or “UI”
Dribbble / Behance	Polished UI and product references specifically
Unsplash / Pexels	Real photography — people, places, textures not tied to another brand
Own screenshots	Direct captures from admired apps already researched in competitive analysis

5. Curate down hard

Aim for 12–20 images maximum on the final board. Past that point it stops being a decision-making tool and becomes a scrapbook. If two images make the same point, cut the weaker one.

6. Test it, don't just admire it

Once assembled, show the board to someone and ask: “what kind of product is this?” If their answer is close to the actual purpose statement, the board is working. If they guess something else entirely — a different audience, a different tone — the board doesn't match the product yet, no matter how good it looks in isolation.

Quick summary: define the feeling in words first → mix image categories, don't rely on UI alone → filter against palette, constraints, and audience authenticity → source broadly → curate to 12–20 → test against the purpose statement before treating the board as final.